

Resolution from Northwestern University American Association of University Professors

Whereas, the first paragraph of the [Faculty Handbook](#) (2021) states “Northwestern University subscribes to the 1940 Statement of Principles on Academic Freedom and Tenure with 1970 Interpretive Comments issued by the American Association of University Professors (AAUP), and the Statement on Professional Ethics adopted by the AAUP in 1966 and revised in 1987 and 2009.” And,

whereas, the Faculty Handbook states, “Freedom in the pursuit and expression of knowledge is fundamental to the life of the institution. Academic freedom creates an environment in which faculty members may pursue their scholarly research, creative activities, publication, and teaching and related activities. It is essential to the university’s fulfillment of its mission to discover, produce and communicate knowledge to students, to colleagues, and to the community at large. This mission depends upon the free search for truth and its free exposition.” And,

whereas, the Faculty Handbook fails to enforce these standards and AAUP standards of shared governance, including by:

- empowering the administration to suspend faculty without appeal based on vague allegations of “impairment” and “disruptive behavior” untethered to specific policy violations;
- empowering the administration to hand-pick faculty for appeals panels in cases in which sanction is imposed as discipline, and not holding faculty elections;
- imposing no specific investigative and appeals deadlines on administrators;
- imposing specific and short deadlines investigative and appeal deadlines on faculty;
- not compensating faculty for participating in mandatory investigations outside the nine-months of paid employment;
- prohibiting faculty from sharing information on their own investigations;
- prohibiting faculty from recording meetings with administrators conducting investigations;
- allowing the University’s General Counsel to participate in sanction hearings, but prohibiting faculty from having their attorney present “during the initiation, attempted settlement, fact-finding, sanctioning, or appeal of an allegation of misconduct or other

grounds for discipline...”,

-allowing the administration to make final decisions that disregard findings of faculty appeals committees, without justification;

-shirking compliance with the [Illinois Personnel Records Review Act](#),

-not protecting faculty intellectual property rights to teaching materials shared on Canvas and other third-party platforms with which the University contracts; and

whereas, a proposed change now under consideration by the Faculty Senate to include suspension from teaching as appealable does not protect the faculty from the infringements on prerogatives of academic freedom and shared governance listed above; and,

whereas, the Faculty Handbook expressly excludes all Research Faculty from protections of the Faculty Handbook; and,

whereas, Research Faculty are included as members of the Faculty Assembly and their academic freedom is crucial to protecting the mission of academic freedom stated in the Faculty Handbook; and,

whereas, the University has [suspended](#) and removed faculty from the campus and teaching in retaliation for protected speech and without the opportunity to appeal; and,

whereas, “If policies and procedures of schools and departments are in conflict with information in this Faculty Handbook, the statements in this handbook take precedence,” according to the Faculty Handbook, thus making amendments to the Faculty Handbook the most efficient vehicle for redress of numerous deficiencies in University policies; and,

whereas, “when the Faculty Assembly is convened with a quorum (10% of membership), it becomes the ultimate legislative body of the faculty at Northwestern University.” And,

whereas, “On its own initiative [the Faculty Assembly] may submit recommendations and resolutions to the Board of Trustees on any matter affecting the general interests of the University.” And,

whereas, the capacity of the Faculty Senate or other bodies of Northwestern to undertake such recommendations and present them to the Provost does not supersede the prerogatives of the Faculty Assembly, including that of submitting a resolution to the Board of Trustees on matters in the Faculty Handbook, and

whereas, the Association of Governing Boards and the American Council of Education, [Statement on Government of Colleges and Universities](#) holds, “The governing board and president should, on questions of faculty status, as in other matters where the faculty has

primary responsibility, concur with the faculty judgment except in rare instances and for compelling reasons which should be stated in detail.” And,

whereas, Northwestern University is a member of the [American Council of Education](#); and,

whereas, the University has a long history of governance decisions in [violation of its Charter’s sole mission of education](#), and has admitted to recent investment decisions that [jeopardize its nonprofit status](#), and,

whereas, the University pursues [unsuccessful, unconstitutional prosecutions](#) of faculty, while forcing its [faculty to seek out their own attorneys](#) to protect research funding, and

whereas, the Board failed to enact the [resolutions passed by the Faculty Assembly in Spring, 2025](#) and [Fall, 2025](#), and,

whereas, disregard of the Faculty Assembly’s vote on the Faculty Handbook can be used as evidence in legal proceedings on behalf of faculty, and,

whereas, absent these changes, the University will not uphold its stated commitment to academic freedom, therefore,

Be it resolved that Northwestern University shall adopt the [Faculty Handbook as amended herein](#) and as endorsed by the Northwestern University American Association of University Professors.